

Arkansas - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-45 underlying baseline with a credible offensive ceiling.
Preseason consensus	unranked, 0 votes · 16th · No. 44
Returning production	55% (No. 57) overall · Off. 55% (No. 66) · Def. 55% (No. 60)
Primer power rating	+5.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	4.4 wins · most likely 4-8
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ - Better in expected record, but with major offensive replacement risk and only a tentative defensive floor
Confidence	Low

2026 identity: OC Tim Cramsey will call a veer-and-shoot-based offense blended with the balanced run/pass profile he used at Memphis, with QB KJ Jackson now named the starter ahead of Memphis transfer QB AJ Hill as Arkansas rebuilds around several transfer starters.

Bottom line: Arkansas should improve on 2-10, but new staff, an unproven QB, massive roster churn and the No. 2 SOS make this one of the league's least stable evaluations.

Beats expectations if: QB KJ Jackson becomes a reliable first-year starter, the rebuilt OL preserves 2025's offensive efficiency, and DC Ron Roberts produces modest defensive improvement.

Disappoints if: The QB/OL transition drags the offense backward while a defense replacing its leading tackler, top ball producers and multiple NFL veterans remains vulnerable.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB decision:** QB KJ Jackson has been named the Week 1 starter after beating out Memphis transfer QB AJ Hill.
- 2 2025 baseline:** Arkansas was much better on offense than its 2-10 record suggests: No. 23 in opponent-adjusted offense and EPA/play, No. 14 in success rate and No. 1 in explosive-play rate in 2025.
- 3 2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense was the mirror image: No. 115 in EPA/play allowed, No. 126 in success rate allowed and No. 134 in explosive-play rate allowed.
- 4 ★ DE Quincy Rhodes Jr.:** DE Quincy Rhodes Jr. returns after 15.5 TFL and 8 sacks and carries preseason second-team All-SEC plus Bednarik recognition.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ gives Arkansas the No. 2 SOS, with the final five games Missouri, at Auburn, South Carolina, at Texas and LSU.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	2-10 (0-8 SEC)	● Very poor
Scoring	32.9 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	454.8 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	191.9 YPG · 5.7 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	8.28 YPA · 22 TD / 11 INT	● Good / above average
Third downs	47.9%	● Elite
Scoring defense	33.8 PPG allowed	● Very poor
Total defense	425.2 YPG allowed	● Very poor
Rush defense	185.9 YPG · 4.7 YPC	● Poor
Pass defense	239.2 YPG · 8.47 YPA · 22 TD allowed	● Very poor

The record hid a dramatic split.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.79 · No. 23	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.124 · No. 23	● Very good
Off. success rate	48.8% · No. 14	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	18.3% · No. 1	● Elite
Havoc allowed	16.5% · No. 98	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	-2.43 · No. 88	● Below average
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.115 · No. 115	● Poor
Def. success rate allowed	46.7% · No. 126	● Very poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	16.3% · No. 134	● Very poor
Havoc created	15.1% · No. 79	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: Arkansas was one of the clearest split-profile teams in 2025: a top-25 offense with the nation's No. 1 explosive-play rate paired with a defense that was bottom 22 or worse in EPA allowed, success rate allowed and explosive-play prevention.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Ryan Silverfield - new external from Memphis HC	● ↔ High-transition reset after a 2-10 season; direction is not assumed positive merely because the prior record was poor.
OC / offensive play-caller	◆ Tim Cramsey - new external from Memphis OC/QB	● ↑ Continuity with Silverfield and confirmed play-calling experience support the install, but he inherits an offense replacing its starting QB.
DC / defensive play-caller	◆ Ron Roberts - new external from Florida DC	● ↔ The clearest schematic opportunity because the 2025 defense was bottom-tier by both traditional and advanced measures.
Co-DC / secondary	◆ Deron Wilson - new external program rehire from Florida DB	● ↔ Adds coordinator/secondary continuity with Roberts from Florida, but the projected secondary is transfer-heavy and not a settled carryover unit.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Aj Hill	Memphis	● ↔ Runner-up in the QB competition and an experienced reserve option behind named starter KJ Jackson.
◆ RB Sutton Smith	Memphis	● ↔ Major RB/return role with Doak Walker and Hornung recognition.
◆ WR Chris Marshall	Boise State	● ↔ Projects in the first receiving group.
◆ WR Jamari Hawkins	Memphis	● ↔ Looks set as the first-group slot receiver.

Out	To	Loss
QB Taylen Green	NFL (Cleveland), Round 6, No. 182	● ↓ 2025 starting QB and total-offense leader leaves for the NFL.
RB Mike Washington Jr.	NFL (Las Vegas), Round 4, No. 122	● ↓ The 1,070-yard 2025 leading rusher is gone.
WR O'Mega Blake	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ The 2025 receiving leader (58-769-5) exits college; only a draft-evaluation/all-star path is confirmed.
OL Fernando Carmona	NFL (Tennessee), Round 5, No. 142	● ↓ Starting OL contributor becomes a fifth-round draft loss.
OL E'Marion Harris	Oklahoma	● ↓ Multi-start 2025 tackle transfers out.

Offensive net: ● ↓ High-end 2025 production is being rebuilt rather than carried over; enough portal talent exists for a functional offense.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Hunter Osborne	Virginia	● ↔ Projects at nose tackle in the first front.
◆ DL Carlon Jones	USC	● ↔ Lines up at defensive tackle.
◆ EDGE Steven Soles Jr.	Kentucky	● ↔ Fits at JACK opposite/around DE Quincy Rhodes Jr.
◆ LB Ja'Quavion Smith	-	● ↔ Looks set at weakside linebacker.

Out	To	Loss
DL Ian Geffrard	Texas	● ↓ Started all 12 games in 2025 before transferring.
LB Xavian Sorey Jr.	NFL (Las Vegas Raiders), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The 2025 team tackles leader exits to a confirmed NFL roster.
DB Kani Walker	NFL (Buffalo Bills), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The 2025 pass-breakup leader exits to a confirmed NFL roster.

Out	To	Loss
CB Julian Neal	NFL (Seattle), Round 3, No. 99	● ↓ 2025 secondary contributor and interception leader becomes a third-round draft loss.
DL Cam Ball	NFL (Indianapolis Colts), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material 2025 DL contributor exits to a confirmed NFL roster.

Defensive net: ● ↔ A full reconstruction around DE Quincy Rhodes Jr.; the portal supplies bodies and upside.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Cramsey-called attack with a veer-and-shoot base and a recent Memphis profile.	The inherited 2025 Arkansas offensive DNA was excellent-top-23 opponent-adjusted/EPA, No. 14 success rate and No. 1 explosive-play rate.	Almost every high-leverage continuity point changes: QB, lead RB, leading WR and multiple OL contributors.
Defense	Roberts-called multiple 4-2-5 built around pressure/negative-play concepts, with DE Quincy Rhodes Jr.	DE Quincy Rhodes Jr. gives the front a legitimate returning disruptor.	The 2025 baseline was poor or very poor almost everywhere.
Special teams	A specialist unit with a projected-average SP+ baseline but a major kicker transition.	SP+ special teams is No. 44, suggesting the model does not see an obvious structural disaster.	The 2025 starting kicker transferred to LSU and no final replacement is established.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	QB KJ Jackson has won the starting job, but he remains unproven as a full-season Power 4 starter.
RB	● B	● ↓	Medium	RB Braylen Russell and RB Sutton Smith offer options after 1,070-yard RB Mike Washington Jr. departs.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	A transfer-heavy first group must replace 2025 receiving leader WR O'Mega Blake and other volume.
TE	● B-	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Jaden Platt returns with Mackey recognition after TE Rohan Jones departs.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	OL Malachi Breland adds 12 starts, but multiple 2025 contributors are gone and the five is rebuilt.
DL/Edge	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	DE Quincy Rhodes Jr. is a proven disruptor while transfers refill a front with major losses.
LB	● C+	● ↓	Low	The group replaces tackles leader LB Xavian Sorey Jr. with newcomers and limited continuity.
Secondary	● C+	● ↓	Low	A transfer-heavy back end replaces multiple veteran and professional departures.
Special teams	● B-	● ↓	Low	SP+ rates the unit No. 44, but the starting kicker departed and the replacement is unsettled.
Coaching	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	HC Ryan Silverfield, OC Tim Cramsey and DC Ron Roberts bring experience and some prior staff continuity.
Overall	● B	● ↑	Low	SP+ No. 44 supports improvement, but new staff, QB uncertainty and newcomer dependence widen the range.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
KJ Jackson	QB	● Unproven Power 4 starter	-	Named Week 1 starter after winning the camp competition to replace Taylen Green.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ AJ Hill (TR: Memphis)	QB	● Experienced reserve / system-transition piece	-	Memphis transfer finished behind KJ Jackson in the starting competition and remains the primary experienced alternative.
Braylen Russell	RB	● Lead/major rotation back	-	Returning back is first in the current RB projection.
◆ Sutton Smith (TR: Memphis)	RB	● Major rotation/return weapon	Doak Walker Award · Paul Hornung Award	Memphis transfer is already projected for major work.
Jaden Platt	TE	● High-upside conference starter	John Mackey Award	Returning first-group tight end becomes more important after Rohan Jones departs.
Quincy Rhodes Jr.	DE	● High-end conference impact defender	SEC Coaches Preseason All-SEC 2nd team · SEC Media Preseason All-SEC 2nd team · Bednarik Award	The clearest proven defender on the roster after 15.5 TFL.
◆ Malachi Breland (TR: Memphis)	OL	● Proven transfer starter / projected LG	-	Twelve Memphis starts in 2025 make him a critical stabilizer for the rebuilt line.
◆ Chris Marshall (TR: Boise State)	WR	● Projected first-group outside receiver	-	One of the principal portal pieces asked to replace the production lost.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Brutal: after two non-P4 home games, every project-team opponent is top-30 SP+ and the final five are all top-26.
Difficulty	● 10/10 · SP+ SOS No. 2
Hardest stretch	Missouri -> at Auburn -> South Carolina -> at Texas -> LSU
Swing games	at Utah, at Vanderbilt, at Auburn, South Carolina
Advantage	The only meaningful structural relief is home North Alabama/Tulsa and a late October bye before the five-game closing gauntlet.
Expected	4.4 wins · likely 4-8
Floor / ceiling	2-10 / 7-5

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Expect a difficult pricing profile: the 2-10 record and last-place SEC poll invite pessimism.
Back them when	Against opponents that cannot punish the rebuilt defense with explosive plays.
Fade/pass when	Against high-end offenses/fronts or when the line assumes the QB/OL transition has already resolved successfully.
Key monitor	KJ Jackson's early efficiency and backup snap plan, final offensive-line continuity, whether the transfer-heavy secondary holds up, and the replacement kicker.
Week 1 baseline	vs. North Alabama: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Arkansas -40.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Arkansas was far better offensively than its 2-10 record, but QB, RB, WR and OL turnover leaves new HC Ryan Silverfield and OC Tim Cramsey rebuilding around newly named starter KJ Jackson. DE Quincy Rhodes Jr. is the defensive centerpiece for DC Ron Roberts after a dreadful 2025 baseline.

A modest record improvement is plausible, but confidence stays low because both units depend heavily on newcomers and SP+ rates the schedule No. 2. The baseline is **4.4 wins · likely 4-8**; the key is whether QB/OL stability and defensive explosive-play prevention improve quickly enough.

About this primer

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Sources: [projected depth chart](#) · [Football Year-by-Year Leaders](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [2026 roster](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [Tim Cramsey bio](#) · [Ron Roberts bio](#) · [2026 roster](#) · [coaching update](#) · [QB1 update](#)

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